Bob Ellis

Service designer · public spaces and everyday services
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Summary

I help public-service teams make complicated journeys easier to navigate. I combine field research, service mapping and prototyping, with an emphasis on accessibility and the practical constraints of the people delivering a service.

Experience

Lead service designer, Common Ground Studio
June 2022 – present
Rotterdam
A fictional design practice working with libraries, neighbourhood services and community organisations. Led research and service design on programmes involving staff across several locations.

- Mapped the complete journey for residents applying for a shared community space, including the letters, phone calls and internal handovers that were missing from the existing process map.
- Ran accessible research sessions with residents who used interpreters, assistive technology or a trusted helper. Adapted consent and task materials so participation did not depend on reading a long form.
- Tested a simplified appointment letter with staff and residents before changing the underlying booking system. Clear preparation instructions reduced avoidable repeat visits.
- Facilitated weekly prototype reviews with front-desk staff, operational managers and the delivery team. Recorded decisions and open questions in one shared place.
- Created a service measurement plan covering completion, repeat contact and confidence, with guidance on how to interpret each measure alongside qualitative evidence.
- Helped the organisation establish an internal research panel with clear retention rules, plain-language invitations and a routine for reviewing who was underrepresented.

Participatory research · accessibility · service operations

Service designer, Canal Works
January 2019 – May 2022
Utrecht
A fictional cooperative helping local organisations improve public-facing services.

- Observed library staff across four branches and mapped how reservations, missing items and accessibility requests moved between the public desk and back-office teams.
- Built a paper prototype of a new wayfinding system, then tested it with visitors before committing to permanent signage. Used finding errors to revise the vocabulary and placement.
- Designed a shared workshop format that combined a short research playback with a practical decision. Teams left with a specific next experiment and an owner.
- Worked with developers on accessible form patterns, including error recovery, saved progress and a consistent explanation of what information was optional.

Education

MA, Design for Society
Delta School of Design
September 2014 – July 2016

- Graduation project on accessible booking journeys for shared public spaces.

BA, Communication Design
Harbour Arts College
September 2010 – June 2014

Methods

Research
Contextual interviews
Field observation
Participatory workshops
Accessible usability testing
Diary studies
Service walkthroughs
Research planning
Consent design

Synthesis
Service blueprints
Evidence mapping
Journey maps
Clear research summaries
Affinity mapping
Opportunity framing
Stakeholder maps
Research playbacks

Delivery
Paper prototypes
Content design
Inclusive facilitation
Small service experiments
Service rehearsals
Accessible forms
Pilot planning
Handover guides

Tools
Figma
FigJam
HTML and CSS

- Prepared a plain-language handover kit that made the research findings, assumptions and unresolved questions usable for the next delivery team.

Journey mapping · facilitation · prototyping

Research assistant, Neighbourhood Lab
September 2016 – December 2018
Delft
A fictional research group studying how residents use shared spaces.

- Organised interviews and observation sessions for a study of community hubs, including evening visits for residents who could not attend during working hours.
- Synthesised field notes into evidence boards and supported the team in distinguishing observed behaviour from assumptions and proposed solutions.
- Created a lightweight archive with consistent consent records, accessible transcripts and a clear separation between public examples and participant information.

Selected Projects

Welcome to the library
A fictional pilot for a more accessible first visit, February 2025 – November 2025

- Designed a simple arrival guide, clearer sign-up instructions and staff prompts for visitors who needed extra assistance.
- Tested each change in one branch before extending it to the remaining locations, with a short observation checklist for staff.

Neighbourhood ideas week
A fictional community consultation programme, March 2024 – March 2024

- Combined walk-up conversations, large-print activity sheets and a small online form so the consultation reached residents beyond the usual workshop participants.

spreadsheets
survey tools
collaborative whiteboards

Languages

Dutch: Native

English: Fluent

German: Conversational

Community

Volunteer workshop facilitator
Neighbourhood gardening
Local history walks

Workshops

Research that survives the handover
A fictional half-day workshop for public-service teams, June 2026

- Participants practise explaining one finding, linking it to evidence and recording the decisions it can reasonably support.

Prototype the conversation
A fictional session for frontline staff and designers, October 2025

- A practical introduction to testing service scripts, letters and support conversations before investing in new software.